



BEFORE

During the 18th and early 19th centuries, Britain, Spain, France, and Russia all laid claim to parts of North America, often without consideration for the American Indian nations who already lived there.

REVOLUTION

In 1783, under the **Treaty of Paris**, 13 North American colonies under British rule gained independence << 228–29 and formed the United States of America.

ESTABLISHING BOUNDARIES

With the Treaty of Paris, the northern border with British

TREATY OF PARIS Canada through the Great Lakes was agreed. In 1783

Britain returned Florida to Spain, which also controlled the Louisiana Territory. Spain ceded the Louisiana Territory back to France in 1800.

NEW STATES

The **1787 Northwest Ordinance** allowed the formation of up to five new states to the northwest of the US on land ceded by various states to the US government. This increased the conflict between settlers and natives. In 1795, 12 American Indian nations were persuaded to sign the **Treaty of Greenville**, giving land to the United States. They were then moved to vacant land in the west.

Ceremonial skull

This buffalo skull was painted by the Blackfoot nation for their ceremonial Sun Dance. The rights of such American Indian nations were usually swept aside by settlers and the US government.

Pioneer spirit

Settlers, such as this family, traveled west across the Great Plains, often in large convoys for safety. The wagons carried all their worldly goods, plus tools for farming and building.

From its beginnings, squashed between the Atlantic Ocean in the east and the Appalachian Mountains in the west, the United States quickly expanded westward to the Mississippi River and beyond. The land between the Appalachians and the Mississippi was ceded by the British at independence. Expansion across the Mississippi began after the Louisiana Purchase in 1803, whereby the French sold the entire Louisiana Territory (see BEFORE) to the US. In May 1804, US president Jefferson sent Meriwether Lewis, his secretary, and William Clark to explore this practically unknown area. The pair set off from St. Louis and sailed up the Missouri River.



DECISIVE MOMENT

FIRST TRANSCONTINENTAL RAILROAD

On May 10, 1869 at Promontory Point, Utah, a grand ceremony marked the opening of the first railroad to cross America. The 1,086 miles (1,738 km) of eastern Union Pacific track and the 690 miles (1,100 km) of the western Central Pacific track were linked. Leland Stanford, president of the Central Pacific Railroad, swung a silver hammer at a golden spike—a bolt made of gold—to symbolically join the tracks. Envoys from the Union Pacific Railroad also took a turn at hammering it home. The US now had its first transcontinental railroad.



Expanding the Frontier

The independent United States of America that emerged in 1783 was, in reality, the United East Coast. The land to its west appeared to be limitless. In the century that followed independence, the frontier was pushed west across the continent until American dominion stretched from ocean to ocean.

With the help of Shoshone guides, they crossed over the Rocky Mountains, and in December 1805 they reached the Pacific coast. The route was hard, but they met friendly Indians and returned with details of the new frontier.

Division of the land

An agreement with Britain in 1818 straightened out the northern border with Canada along the 49th parallel line of latitude. Another agreement in 1842 confirmed the northeast border in Maine. To the south, Florida was acquired from Spain between 1813 and 1819. This led to conflict with the Seminole nation. To deal with hostilities, the government passed the Indian Removal Act in 1830, giving the US president power to move tribes

west across the Mississippi to the “Indian Territory” (now Oklahoma). The Cherokees were the first to arrive, having been displaced by the discovery of gold in their home in Georgia. In 1838, the “Trail of Tears” involved the enforced removal of about 17,000 Cherokees; 4,000 died, often from disease contracted in transportation camps.

Californian gold rush

The discovery of gold in the Lower Sacramento Valley in December 1848 lured prospectors west to California. They arrived by land and sea to seek their fortune, often carrying few possessions apart from a tin bowl to pan for gold.

